It was mostly photos of Africa. I knew she'd been there, because I'd studied her Instagram page too; I'd seen photos of her hanging out with gorillas in Rwanda.

She said she'd done some aid work there as well. With children. We shared thoughts about Africa, photography, travel.

Eventually we exchanged phone numbers, and migrated the conversation over to text, going late into the night. In the morning I moved from Nott Cott to the car, without a pause in the texting. I texted with her throughout the long drive to Sir Keith's place, continued through Sir Keith's hall—*How you doing, Sir Keith?*—and up the stairs and into his guestroom, where I locked the door and remained holed up, texting. I sat on the bed texting like a teenager until it was time to have dinner with Sir Keith and his family. Then, after dessert, I quickly returned to the guestroom and resumed texting.

I couldn't type fast enough. My thumbs were cramping. There was so much to say, we had so much in common, though we came from such different worlds. She was American, I was British. She was well-educated, I was decidedly not. She was free as a bird, I was in a gilded cage. And yet none of these differences felt disqualifying or even important. On the contrary, they felt organic, energizing. The contradictions created a sense of:

Hey…I know you.

But also: I need to know you.

Hey, I've known you forever.

But also: I've been searching for you forever.

Hey, thank God you've arrived.

But also: What took you so long?

Sir Keith's guestroom looked out onto an estuary. Many times, mid-text, I'd walk over to the window and gaze out. The view made me think of the Okavango. It made me think also of destiny, and serendipity. That convergence of river and sea, land and sky reinforced a vague sense of big things coming together.

It occurred to me how uncanny, how surreal, how bizarre, that this marathon conversation should have begun on July 1, 2016.

My mother's fifty-fifth birthday.